



DURING ANDREY RUBLEV'S (RIGHT) 6-4, 5-7, 6-2 ROUND-ROBIN LOSS TO THE MILD-MANNERED CASPER RUUD (LEFT), THE RUSSIAN'S DEMONS RETURNED

Masters 1000 titles in Rome on clay and Paris indoors just two weeks before Riyadh. Besides momentum, the 6'6" German carried confidence from winning the ATP Finals in 2018 by defeating Federer (semis) and Djokovic (final), and again in 2021, overcoming Djokovic (semis) and Medvedev (final).

Fritz's advantage was more personal and recent. The 27-year-old American had beaten Zverev in their last three encounters, all in 2024, with the most significant victories coming in a tough five-setter at Wimbledon and a four-setter at the US Open. Additionally, in a breakthrough year, Fritz reached his first Major final at Flushing Meadows and ascended to

a career-high ranking of No. 5.

This semifinal featured two heavyweight servers but average returners. Zverev ranked No. 1 among ATP Serve Leaders, with Fritz at No. 7. But neither ranked among the top 25 Return Leaders. This crucial 'under pressure' rating placed Fritz at No. 17 and Zverev at No. 23.

Though not a vast difference, Fritz held a significant lead in tiebreaks won, 65.6 per cent compared to 60 per cent. In their

head-to-head encounters, Fritz had won six of eight tiebreaks.

These stats proved relevant in Fritz's razor-thin 6-3, 3-6, 7-6 (3) victory. In fairness, it was more than just a serving contest, despite each player managing only one service break. Both displayed powerful groundstrokes, excellent mobility, and grit.

In the deciding set, Zverev saved three break points in the eighth game and pounded his trademark backhand down the line to hold for